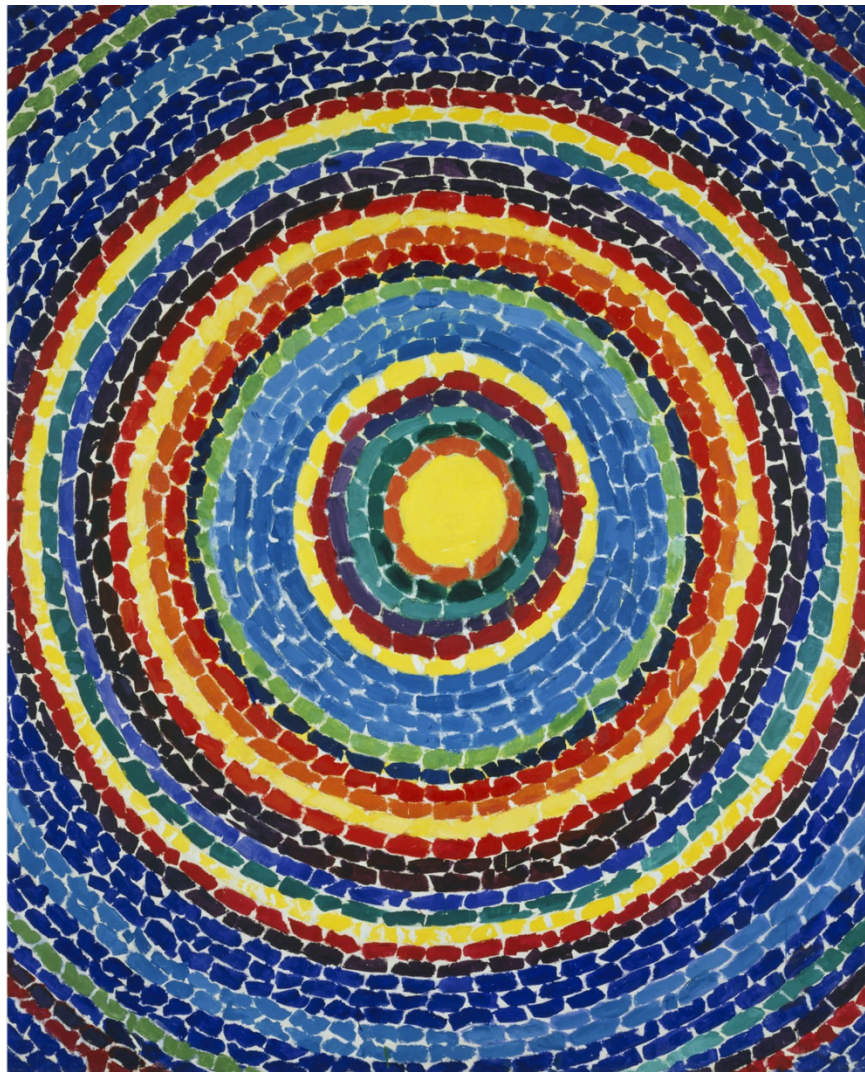


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Turning Over Tables:
A Lenten Call for Disrupting Power
Repent – Lent 3*

March 23rd, 2025



Splash Down Apollo 13, 1970, Alma Thomas

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on FOUNDATION and CWM RHONDDA

Meditation on *O ignis Spiritus paracliti* (Hildegard von Bingen)

Praeludium in D, WV 31 (Heinrich Scheidemann) and Improvisation

Andante espressivo (Hedwige Chrétien) and Improvisation

Close Path (S.J. Rozzo) and Improvisation

Apotheosis from *Journey* (Austin Wintory) and Improvisation

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Lenten Words of Gathering

Megan Mascena & Rev. Tanaka Pack

These days, when slippery words and shaded truths are commonplace,
we gather to proclaim the honest good news of God's love for all persons.

These days, when global divisions abound and internal stresses take their toll,
we gather to share a faith that is a source of healing and comfort.

These days, when demands for justice and commitment and compassion are great,
we gather to strengthen ourselves and one another for the task of being a people
who work for change.

We give thanks to the Divine for gathering us together as this community of faith.

This day we shall work to change ourselves, and our world, turning over tables that exclude, as
we share and strengthen our resolve to follow in the way of Jesus the Christ, who sets a table
where all are welcome and fed.

This morning may it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Lenten Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering**

From Wisdom Emerging

FOUNDATION

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space
for people converging in safety and grace,
to shelter the freedom of one and of all
in Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
with others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,
we walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more
of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,
we joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,
old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;
protecting all the freedoms with every new choice,
we follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

-lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Holy One,
as we continue
on our Lenten Journey,
help us to sense where change is required.
To change ourselves and our world.
To know the need for it.
To deal with the pain of it.
To feel the joy of it.
To undertake this journey
without understanding the destination.

Help us in these days, O God,
to lean in and listen for the sacred art
of the way of the Christ,
who turned over tables in response to
Love's call.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Turn Back, O Man" from *Godspell*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Soloist*

STEPHEN SCHWARTZ

***The Lord's Prayer**

Megan Mascena

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.*

*And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

We travel this path of life through all its twists and turns,
God before us and behind us,
Christ beside us on our left and right,
the Spirit deep within.

Let us not hurry and move ahead of each other.
Let us not worry and move without God.
Let us not give up and move away from community.
For you, O God, hold us firm to the hope
to which you call us.

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition

from the Gospel of Matthew

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

*Loving God,
Grant us the serenity to accept ourselves as we are,
to refuse to be at war with our own flesh,
to tend to our needs, our pain, our fears,
gently and without judgment.*

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Megan Mascena

Rev. Tanaka Pack

*Grant us the courage to receive
the accountability of others
that supports our unlearning of dominance,
encourages us towards healing,
and challenges us to deepen
our practice of love.*

*Grant us the wisdom to know the difference
between invitations to learn
and reasons to self-loath;
between the posture of perfectionism
and the labors of freedom and transformation;
between the entrapments of guilt and shame
and the joy of doing things differently.*

*In all things, lead us in the ways of liberation,
collective and intimate.
Amen and Amen!*

[Serenity Remix by Rev. M. Jade Kaiser / adapt]

Meditation Anthem

"Jesus Christ The Apple Tree"
Cathedral Choir

ELIZABETH POSTON

Sermon

Repent

Rev. Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Fregin

Prayer of Blessing

Let us pray together...
*At this table Holy One, make us one
with each other
and with all who share this feast.
Unite us in faith,
encourage us in hope,
inspire us to love,
that we may serve you
and your world.
Amen and Amen.*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

"Abide With Me"
Cathedral Choir Tenors and Basses

HENRY LYLE arr. MOSES HOGAN

*Lenten Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

*Prayer of Offering

Megan Mascena

Holy One, we give thanks
for the truth that has been inscribed on our hearts
and into the heart of every human being,
there to be read and revered.

We give thanks that there are ways of perceiving and sensitives of knowing
hidden deep in the sacredness of our souls,
waiting to be discovered,
ready to be set free.

As we bring our gifts and ourselves to you this day,
open our senses to wisdom's inner promptings
that we may give voice to what we hear in our souls,
and be changed for the healing of the world.

And then, O God, in the days to come,
may we listen for truth in every living soul
and together, may we be changed for the well-being of the world.

- J. Phillip Newell, Prayer for Wisdom

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us.

Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

As we go into this week,
may we find and follow
the rhythms that bring life.

May we let go of the patterns
that confine and constrain.

May our turning and returning
trace pathways of peace,
and may each movement of courage we take
make a life-giving way.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Choral Response

“Please, God, Heal Us”
Cathedral Choir

arr. KAREN SIEGEL

Lenten Hymn for the Journey *God of Change and God of Glory

CWM RHONDDA

God of change and God of glory,
God of time and God of space,
When we fear our future story,
Give to us your loving grace.
Grant us wisdom, grant us courage,
Give us still the gift to praise,
Give us still the gift to praise.

God of many different colors,
God of many different signs,
You have made all of us different,
Blessings for all humankind.
Grant us wisdom, grant us courage,
Let your love cast out our fear,
Let your love cast out our fear.

Freshness of the light of morning,
Freshness of the light of night,
You are still creating stories
Of your grace and of your light.
Grant us wisdom, grant us courage,
For the gifts from one great heart,
For the gifts from one great heart.
-lyrics adapted from A. Carmines

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence
Postlude in F minor (Luise Adolpha Le Beau)

Inside The Music

“Repentance is one of those ideas that appears in a lot of music. In the compassion-driven space we try to create in The Cathedral, the ways in which repentance is often depicted struggles against our understanding. This week’s music explores a number of settings that ask new questions of repentance. “Turn Back, O Man” from *Godpell* offers a tongue-and-cheek approach. Schwartz’s vaudevillian, 1930s night club setting of an old hymn welcomes the party atmosphere that the text might be understood to be shaming. The Jesus character has a brief interlude, which we will begin with today, where he says that all people will be one. Schwartz seems to be telling us that the traditional shame-filled idea of repentance mislabels the personal experience. Shaming mistakes the power of repentance to bring clarity, replacing it instead with a way to wield power over another for actions you may not approve of. Within his music we hear a celebration of difference that asks us to question what repentance looks like from the outside, and feels like internally. Elizabeth Poston’s setting of the folk song “Jesus Christ the

Apple Tree” settles into that a little further. “I’m weary with my former toil” the fourth verse says. Repentance, in the words of the agriculturalists who originally wrote the song, begins when we lay down the load we’ve been carrying and seek a different path. The apple tree metaphor for Christ is an interesting one. In this context, the prolific fruit bearing nature of the tree gives it the promise of abundance in the absence of that burden. And Moses Hogan’s setting of “Abide With Me” draws us into the intimacy of the process. His highly chromatic barbershop-style arrangement asks new questions of a well-known hymn. Although barbershop, or “close harmony,” in many ways, he puts the melody in the top voice as we would do with a hymn. In traditional barbershop the top voice is a harmony part, with the melody in the middle. That difference creates an even greater sense of churning and motion, as the chromaticism he employs creates persistent harmonic tension and release. That tension-release feels, to me, like the experience of seeking newness. What does it mean to seek for the divine to abide within you? Hogan suggests that the question itself has energy that moves and twists and motivates change. A particularly interesting moment occurs on the words “Thou who changest not.” Instead of using the unchanging melody, as he does throughout the piece, in that one moment the lead voice changes notes. It’s a non-so-subtle text painting to help us remember that even as we seek to draw from a stable well of giving life, we recognize that we will change for it.” ~ Dr. David Harris